

Civilian women

Due to the ARVN draft on the one hand, and the appeal of fighting for the insurgency on the other, the men left in villages and refugee camps tended to be very old or very young. It was not unusual, in contested areas, for young women to be widowed many times as their husbands were killed in combat. This left women and girls to support entire families. Some found work on American bases: digging ditches, peeling potatoes, or as “hootch maids” cleaning up after American servicemen. Lacking other options, many women also worked as sex workers in the nightclubs and massage parlors that sprang up around the bases, or offered themselves directly to US soldiers, sometimes in exchange for food. Whatever choices these women made, they were usually driven by their commitment to family.

Vietnamese women continued to assert their influence on the war until its final days. Notably, Nguyen Thi Binh served as the foreign minister of the Provisional Revolutionary Government (Viet Cong) and was one of the signers of the 1972 Paris Accords.



Staying on guard

Two female workers talk in a factory serving the North Vietnamese Army in Hanoi in 1965. As US air attacks on North Vietnam increased, workers took to keeping rifles close by as a precaution.